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UNVARNISHED

The U in UAT — kind of important...

Serious when it matters.

About InvestPuppy

InvestPuppy builds Vektor, a systematic portfolio management platform for wealth management professionals.

What this series is

Every experienced practitioner thinks it. Almost nobody publishes it: *there has to be a better way.*

We thought it long enough that we went and built one.

Before that, we spent decades in the rooms.

The same project was failing for the third time. The project plan had been signed off before anyone had understood the first requirement.

The relationship was too warm for anyone to say so.

It isn't incompetence.

It's the incentive structure doing its job perfectly.

Nobody planned it this way. Nobody needed to.

We got frustrated enough to write it down. Then frustrated enough to build something. These papers are the writing-it-down part.

The something we built is a separate conversation.

The UAT sign-off document has the right signatures on it. The signatories were not users of the system. They were consultants working from test scripts written by other consultants, testing a configuration reviewed by a project team that had not spoken to the people who would use it in production. The document says PASS. The system goes live. Three weeks later, the people who use it every day explain, at length, why it does not.

1. What the U Is For

User Acceptance Testing. Three words. Each one is load-bearing.

Testing means that something is being evaluated against a standard. *Acceptance* means that the evaluation results in a judgment — this works, or it does not. *User* means that the person making that judgment is the person who will use the system in production, on real transactions, under real conditions, with real consequences for getting it wrong.

Remove the user from User Acceptance Testing and you have acceptance testing.

Which is a different thing. Acceptance testing establishes whether the system meets the specification. UAT establishes whether the system works for the people whose working lives depend on it. These are not the same test. A system can pass acceptance testing and fail UAT. This happens. It is, in fact, one of the most common outcomes in financial software implementation.

The difference between the two tests is not technical. It is human. It is the difference between a system that does what it was specified to do and a system that does what the users actually need it to do. The specification was produced before the discovery was complete, before all the stakeholders were in the room, and before anyone had documented the workarounds and exceptions the users handle every day. The gap between the specification and the reality is exactly the gap that UAT is designed to find. It cannot find that gap if the users are not running the test.

2. How the Outsourcing Happens

The decision to outsource UAT is rarely announced as a decision. It arrives as a resource allocation, a timeline pressure, or a project management convenience.

The users are busy. The system is going live in six weeks. The project team has UAT test scripts. The consulting firm has testers. The testers are available. The users are not. The project manager makes a practical decision: the consultants will run the UAT. The users will be available for sign-off queries if needed.

This is not cynicism. It is a rational response to a genuine resourcing constraint. The problem is that the rational response to the resourcing constraint produces exactly the outcome the UAT phase was designed to prevent.

The users are busy because the organisation has not protected their time for UAT. The organisation has not protected their time for UAT because UAT has been treated as a project team activity rather than an operational activity. It has been scheduled around the project's needs rather than the users' availability. The resourcing constraint that makes consultant-led UAT feel necessary is a planning failure, not a fixed condition. It was created by the same project planning process that will later cite it as the reason UAT was outsourced.

3. What the Consultant's UAT Actually Tests

A consultant running UAT with a test script is not testing whether the system works. They are testing whether the system produces the outputs described in the test script, given the inputs described in the test script, in the sequence described in the test script.

This is a narrower question. It excludes, by design, everything that is not in the test script. It excludes the transaction that occurs twice a month and was not in the test script because nobody thought to include it. It excludes the workflow exception that the operations team handles manually and never mentioned during requirements gathering because they assumed the system would handle it automatically. It excludes the report that the risk team runs every Friday that was not in the standard reports list because the risk team was not in the specification workshop.

The consultant passes these tests because the tests do not test these things.

In a regulated environment, the gap between what was tested and what was needed is not only an operational problem. A reporting process that fails in its first post-live run, because the compliance function was not

represented in the UAT, is a reportable event. The consultant who signed the PASS is not the one who reports it.

The test script was written from the specification. The specification was written from the workshops. The workshops were attended by the stakeholders who were available.

The users who were not available did not attend the workshops, did not shape the specification, and did not write the test scripts. A consultant running those test scripts is not testing whether the system works for the users. They are testing whether the system is consistent with a document that the users had limited input into.

The U was removed long before the UAT phase began.

4. What Real UAT Looks Like

Real UAT is operationally inconvenient. It requires the users to stop doing their jobs for long enough to test the system that will change their jobs. It requires the organisation to treat that time as a legitimate operational cost, not as a project overhead to be minimised. It requires test scripts that were written with user input, not only from the specification. And it requires someone with the authority to say, without commercial consequence, that the system is not ready.

That last requirement is the hardest one. The user who runs UAT and finds that the system does not work for them is not raising a problem. They are doing their job. The organisation that has outsourced UAT to a consultant has, among other things, removed the person most likely to say that the system is not ready — and replaced them with a person whose engagement ends when the

milestone is closed.

Three things that make UAT real rather than documentary:

One. Users — the actual people who will use the system in production — run the tests. Not a representative, not a delegate, not a consultant with a test script. The person who processes the transactions, produces the reports, handles the exceptions. That person.

Two. The test scripts include the transactions that are not in the specification. The exceptions, the edge cases, the processes the users know exist and the project team does not. These are identified in a test script workshop attended by users before UAT begins — not assembled from the specification alone.

Three. The sign-off authority rests with the users, not with the project team. A UAT phase in which the project manager can override a user's rejection of a test case is not a UAT phase. It is a documentation exercise. The user's judgment is the test. Everything else is administration.

The organisation that protects user time for UAT, builds test scripts from user knowledge, and gives users genuine sign-off authority will find that UAT takes longer than the project plan anticipated. It will also find that go-live is not followed by three weeks of post-live crisis. The time is not lost. It is moved from after go-live to before it, where it costs a fraction of what it costs later.

User Acceptance Testing.

The word 'user' is not decorative.